

# Moodboard — UX Research

Cascadia AI Hackathon 2026 · 3 User Personas + Journey Map · Dianne Ting, sole designer

## Core product capabilities

① READ THE SPACE

AI analyses the user's uploaded room photo — detecting existing colours, furniture, lighting, and layout.

② UNDERSTAND STYLE INTENT

Visual style tiles + budget input let the AI infer what the user actually wants — without asking them to describe it.

③ WEB SEARCH FOR PRODUCTS

AI searches the web in real time for products that match the detected style, palette, and budget — not a fixed database.

④ RECOMMEND A SHOPPING LIST

Curated product cards with prices, purchase links, and a "why this fits" reason for each item. Running budget tracker included.

★ ⑤ COMPOSITE INTO ROOM PHOTO

AI places the recommended products into the user's actual uploaded photo — so they can see how the room would look before buying anything.

⑥ EXPORT: PHOTO + SHOPPING LIST

Final output: the synthesised room photo + full shopping list as a downloadable PDF or shareable link. The plan they can return to.

**End-to-end flow:** Upload photo → Set budget → Tap style tiles → AI reads space + searches web → See products in your actual room (composited photo) → Save photo + shopping list

## User personas

● Persona 1 — Alex, 28



Alex, 28

Existing renter

Home office

\$350 budget

Remote worker · 1-bedroom · bought furniture piecemeal over 2 years

"Give me suggestions. Don't tell me to prompt it — I usually don't know what I want."

GOALS

- ◆ Make the home office feel **visually cohesive** — everything looks like it belongs together
- ◆ Get a **saved reference plan** to shop from gradually — not buy everything today
- ◆ **Discover what they like** by seeing it — not by having to describe it first

PAIN POINTS

- 1 **Items don't match**  
Bought pieces separately — room feels random even after real money spent
- 2 **Can't articulate their style**  
Scrolls Pinterest but can't translate inspiration into a purchase decision
- 3 **Decision fatigue**

- ◆ Stay within \$350 without manually tracking spend across sessions

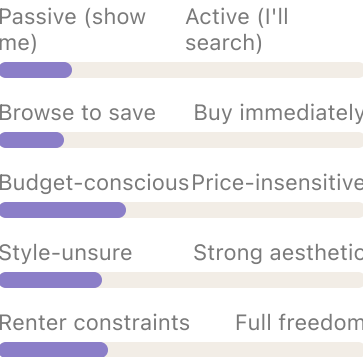
Too many options on Wayfair / IKEA with no filter for "fits my aesthetic"

- 4 **No trusted starting point**  
Interior designers cost \$150–500/hr. Friends' taste doesn't match theirs.
- 5 **Budget blind spots**  
Loses track of total spend across multiple shopping sessions

BEHAVIOURS

- 📌 Saves Pinterest boards but never acts on them
- 📱 Scrolls Instagram / TikTok decor content passively
- 🛒 Impulse-buys single items on Wayfair / IKEA without a plan
- 🕒 Puts off redecorating — feels overwhelming
- 💬 Shares ideas with a partner before committing

ATTITUDE SPECTRUM



WHAT SUCCESS LOOKS LIKE

- Sees a style they didn't know they liked — and immediately recognises it as *theirs*
- Gets 6–8 products that all feel like they belong in the same room
- Downloads the moodboard PDF and shares it — feels proud of the plan
- Comes back weeks later and still has the plan to shop from

Persona 2 — Jordan, 26



Jordan, 26

New mover

Fresh start

\$600 budget

Just signed a lease on their first solo apartment · moved from shared housing · room mostly empty

"I don't even know where to start. The room is just... blank."

GOALS

- ◆ Get a **starting kit** — the essential 6–10 pieces that define the room's direction
- ◆ Commit to a **style identity** they won't regret 6 months from now
- ◆ See a clear **spend breakdown** — where is the budget going and in what order?
- ◆ Have something **ready to buy soon** — the empty room needs furniture, not a wish list

PAIN POINTS

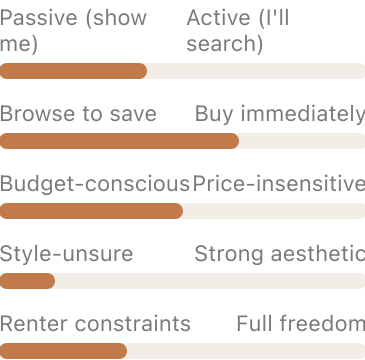
- 1 **Blank canvas paralysis**  
No existing pieces to anchor from — every decision feels like it matters more
- 2 **Fear of style regret**  
"What if I pick Scandinavian and hate it in 3 months?" — can't commit without seeing the full picture first
- 3 **Too many starting points**  
Every guide says "start with the sofa" — but which sofa? From where? In what colour?

- 4 **Budget allocation anxiety**  
\$600 sounds like a lot until you price out a sofa — needs help prioritising what to spend on
- 5 **Urgency + overwhelm**  
The room needs furniture now — but buying random things fast is exactly how rooms end up looking random

BEHAVIOURS

- Browses IKEA and Article for starting points
- Screenshots "room tour" videos on YouTube
- Asks friends "does this go together?" before buying
- More willing to buy soon — the room is empty
- Wants to understand spend priority (sofa vs. lamp vs. rug)

ATTITUDE SPECTRUM



WHAT SUCCESS LOOKS LIKE

- Sees a complete room vision — not just individual items, but how they fit together
- Gets a prioritised shopping order ("start with the rug, it sets the tone")
- Walks away with 3–4 things they can buy this week to make the room feel like home
- Feels confident in the style direction — not worried they'll regret it

Persona 3 — Maya, 21



Maya, 21

Student / new grad

First apartment

\$120 budget

College senior or recent grad · first real apartment (not dorms) · shops IKEA, Facebook Marketplace, thrift

"I want it to look curated, not cheap. But I literally have \$120."

GOALS

- ◆ Make the room look **intentional and curated** — not thrown together on a budget
- ◆ Find pieces that are **under \$30 each** — IKEA, thrift, or dupes are all fine
- ◆ Get something to **screenshot and share** — TikTok "room makeover" moment
- ◆ Prove that **good taste ≠ expensive** to herself and anyone who visits

PAIN POINTS

- 1 **Everything costs too much**  
AI tools and "room makeover" content always recommend things way out of her budget
- 2 **Style exists, execution doesn't**  
Follows the right accounts, knows the aesthetics she wants — just can't afford the real thing
- 3 **Thrift hunting is time-consuming**  
Can find good things secondhand but it takes hours — needs a starting checklist

- 4

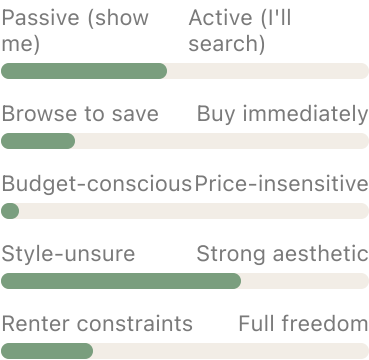
**Feels excluded from design tools**  
"This tool is for people with real budgets" — distrust before she even starts
- 5

**Sparse room = hard to photograph**  
Room doesn't look like much yet — worried AI can't work with what she has

BEHAVIOURS

- Heavy TikTok / Instagram — follows "budget room makeover" creators
- IKEA + Facebook Marketplace + thrift is her default shopping stack
- Shares room progress on her Close Friends story
- Saves "dupe" roundups — affordable versions of expensive items
- Gradual shopper — adds one piece at a time as she has money

ATTITUDE SPECTRUM



WHAT SUCCESS LOOKS LIKE

- Gets a moodboard plan that actually stays under \$120 — no sticker shock
- Sees IKEA / thrift-friendly items, not luxury brands she can't afford
- Has a list she can reference across multiple small shopping trips
- Room goes from sparse → intentional in 3 purchases — and she can share the before/after

PERSONA COMPARISON AT A GLANCE

|                   | Alex, 28                      | Jordan, 26                     | Maya, 21                              |
|-------------------|-------------------------------|--------------------------------|---------------------------------------|
| Life stage        | Settled renter                | New mover                      | Student / new grad                    |
| Budget            | \$350                         | \$600                          | \$120                                 |
| Room state        | Mismatched existing pieces    | Near-empty, starting fresh     | Sparse / bare                         |
| Style clarity     | Low — can't articulate it     | Very low — blank canvas        | Medium — knows the look, not the path |
| Shopping timeline | Weeks/months (gradual)        | Soon — empty room urgency      | Gradual — one item at a time          |
| Top fear          | Things won't match            | Will regret the style choice   | Everything costs too much             |
| Primary CTA       | Download PDF to revisit later | "Ready to buy" — link out fast | Save / share the plan                 |

# User journey map — shared flow with persona callouts

All 3 personas follow the same 7-stage flow. Callout rows show where each persona diverges in emotion, pain, or need.

● Alex — existing renter   ● Jordan — new mover   ● Maya — student

|                 | ● 1 · Trigger                                                                                     | ● 2 · Discovery                                                                                | ● 3 · Upload                                                                                            | ● 4 · Style pick                                                                                           | ● 5 · AI magic                                                                                         |
|-----------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Actions         | Feels something is off with the room — decides to finally do something about it                   | Discovers Moodboard (Instagram, word of mouth). Lands on hero page.                            | Takes 2–3 photos on phone. Uploads. Sees thumbnails confirm upload worked.                              | Sets budget. Scrolls visual style tiles. Taps ones that feel right. No typing.                             | Watches animated steps: "Reading your space... Searching the web... Found 8 matching products..."      |
| ● Alex thinks   | "I've spent money but it still looks off."                                                        | "You just upload photos? I don't have to describe anything?"                                   | "Hope the photo is good enough. Should I clean up first?"                                               | "I like this one. I don't need to know what it's called."                                                  | "It's actually searching for real products that match my room."                                        |
| ● Jordan thinks | "The room is just empty. I don't know what style I even want."                                    | "Does this work if I don't have furniture yet?"                                                | "I barely have anything to photograph. Will this still work?"                                           | "I need to commit to something. What if I pick wrong?"                                                     | "It's searching the web for real products right now?"                                                  |
| ● Maya thinks   | "I want it to look like a real apartment, not a dorm."                                            | "This better not show me things I can't afford."                                               | "My room is kind of sparse. Will AI know what to do with this?"                                         | "I need to set my budget first so it doesn't waste my time."                                               | "Please be things under \$30. Please."                                                                 |
| Emotion         | <br>Frustrated | <br>Curious | <br>Slightly anxious | <br>Relaxed & engaged | <br>Anticipating  |
| Pain points     | <div>no starting point</div> Doesn't know what's wrong, just feels wrong                          | <div>trust barrier</div> "Another AI gimmick?" — needs to feel legit fast                      | <div>photo anxiety</div> Worries a messy or sparse photo will ruin the results                          | <div>decision fatigue</div> Too many choices = paralysis. Budget-setting first helps Maya.                 | <div>dead time</div> Web search takes time — wait feels long with no feedback. Need animated progress. |

|               | ● 1 · Trigger                                                                                                                                            | ● 2 · Discovery                                                                      | ● 3 · Upload                                                                                                                          | ● 4 · Style pick                                                                                                                      | ● 5 · AI magic                                                                                                                                                 |
|---------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Opportunities | <div>hero copy</div> <p>Lead with the mismatch pain: "Your pieces don't talk to each other." Jordan/Maya need sub-copy that nods to their situation.</p> | <div>social proof</div> <p>Show a before/after room on landing page in 3 seconds</p> | <div>photo tips</div> <p>Show "good enough" example — messy is fine. Add "I'm starting fresh — skip this" option for Jordan/Maya.</p> | <div>★ key UX call</div> <p>Budget filter BEFORE style tiles. Then 8–12 real room photos, no text box. AI infers style from taps.</p> | <div>magic loading</div> <p>Show real steps: "Reading your space... Searching the web... Found 8 products that match..." — makes the wait feel purposeful.</p> |

Core design principles

**1 — Show, don't ask**

Users can't articulate what they want. Every input must be visual and reactive — never an open text prompt. Budget is set by a slider, not a form field.

**2 — Cohesion is the promise**

The core pain is mismatch. Every product card should reinforce "these go together" — not just individual picks. Cohesion score % for Alex; starter-kit framing for Jordan.

**3 — Save for later is the CTA**

None of these users buy immediately on first session. The moodboard PDF + email/share option is the real conversion moment. "Buy now" links are secondary, inside the card.